NOT MEASUREMENT SENSITIVE

MIL-DTL-11589F
15 December 1995
SUPERSEDING
MIL-R-11589E
28 February 1986
MIL-R-14655
29 March 1989

DETAIL SPECIFICATION

RIBBON, AWARDS, GENERAL SPECIFICATION FOR

This specification is approved for use by all Departments and Agencies of the Department of Defense.

1. SCOPE

1.1 Scope. This specification covers the general requirements of rayon ribbons used by the Department of Defense and various Federal Agencies (see 6.1).

1.2 Classification. Ribbon awards established by this specification shall be as specified on the applicable military specification sheet (see 2.2).

2. APPLICABLE DOCUMENTS

2.1 General. The documents listed in this section are specified in sections 3 and 4 of this specification. This section does not include documents cited in other sections of this specification or recommended for additional information or as examples. While every effort has been made to ensure the completeness of this list, document users are cautioned that they must meet all specified requirements documents cited in sections 3 and 4 of this specification, whether or not they are listed.

2.2 Government documents.

2.2.1 Specifications, standards, and handbooks. The following specifications, standards and handbooks form a part of this document to the extent specified herein. Unless otherwise specified, the issues of these documents are those listed in the issue of the Department of Defense Index of Specifications and Standards (DoDISS) and supplement thereto, cited in the solicitation (see 6.2).

SPECIFICATION SHEETS

(See supplement 1 for list of specification sheets.)

Beneficial comments (recommendations, additions, deletions) and any pertinent data which may be of use in preparing this document should be addressed to: Director, The Institute of Heraldry, US Army, 9325 Gunston Road, Room S112, Fort Belvoir, VA 22060-5579, by using the Standardization Document Improvement Proposal (DD Form 1426) appearing at the end of this document.

AMSC N/A FSC 8455
DISTRIBUTION STATEMENT A. Approved for public release; distribution is unlimited.

Source: https://assist.dla.mil -- Downloaded: 2026-10-17T18:22Z
Check the source to verify that this is the current version before use.

(Unless otherwise indicated, copies of the above specifications, standards and handbooks are available from the Standardization Document Order Desk, 700 Robbins Avenue, Building 4D, Philadelphia, PA 19111-5094.)

2.2.2 Other Government documents, drawings and publications. The following other Government documents, drawings, and publications form a part of this document to the extent specified herein. Unless otherwise specified, the issues are those cited in the solicitation.

Department of Defense Standard Shades for Heraldic Yarns for Embroidery and Ribbons, 1993 Edition

(Application for copies of the Department of Defense Standard Shades for Heraldic Yarns for Embroidery and Ribbons, 1993 Edition should be addressed to Merit Ribbon Company, Inc., 30 David's Drive, Hauppauge, New York, NY 11788.)

(Copies of specifications, standards, drawings and specification sheets required by the contractors in connection with specific procurement functions should be obtained from the procuring activity or as directed by the contracting officer.)

2.3 Order of precedence. In the event of a conflict between the text of this document and the references cited herein (except for related associated specifications or specification sheets), the text of this document takes precedence. Nothing in this document, however, supersedes applicable laws and regulations unless a specific exemption has been obtained.

3. REQUIREMENTS

3.1 Specification sheets. The individual item requirements shall be as specified herein and in accordance with the applicable specification sheet. In the event of any conflict between the requirements of this specification and the specification sheet, the latter shall govern.

3.2 First article. When specified (see 6.2), a sample shall be subjected to first article inspection in accordance with 4.3.

3.3 Materials. Materials shall be as specified herein.

3.3.1 Yarn. The yarn shall be a continuous filament, bright regenerated cellulose rayon of the viscose or cuprammonium type with not less than 20 filaments for the single yarn. The denier (size) for warp and filling yarn shall be as specified in 3.4.2.

3.3.2 Color. The individual color of the yarns used in the ribbon shall conform to the cable numbers designated by the Department of Defense Standard Shades for Heraldic Yarns for Embroidery and Ribbons, 1993 Edition and specified in individual specification sheets (see 6.2). The colors of yarn shall match the yarn sample indicated in the Department of Defense Standard Shades for Heraldic Yarns for Embroidery and Ribbons under artificial daylight having a color temperature of 7000 $\pm$ 500 degrees Kelvin and shall be a good approximation to the yarn sample under incandescent lamp light at 2850 $\pm$ 100 degrees Kelvin.

3.3.2.1 Colorfastness. The yarn shall show not less than good colorfastness to crocking, wet-dry cleaning, water and light when tested as specified in 4.4.1.1.

3.4 Construction.

Source: https://assist.dla.mil -- Downloaded: 2026-10-17T18:22Z
Check the source to verify that this is the current version before use.

3.4.1 Weave.

3.4.1.1 Ground. With the exception of the 2-3/4 inch (70 mm) streamer ribbon, the ground of all ribbons shall be woven with a gros grain weave. The ground of the 2-3/4 inch (70 mm) streamer ribbon shall be woven with a plain weave.

3.4.1.2 Selvage. Unless otherwise specified, the selvage of the ribbons shall be woven with a 3 and 1 corkscrew weave. The World War I Victory ribbon and the Superior Cadet Award ribbons shall be woven without a special weave along each side of the ribbon.

3.4.1.2.1 Selvage ends. The number of selvage ends along each side of the ribbon shall be 20 ends unless otherwise specified.

3.4.2 Physical requirements. Except for the ribbons listed in 3.4.2.1, the physical requirements of the finished ribbons shall be as stated in Table I when tested as specified in 4.2. The layout of the warp yarn shall be as specified on applicable specification sheet.

TABLE I. Physical Requirements.

TYPE	WIDTH IN INCHES/MM + 1/16-0 inch (+0.16-0 mm)	TOTAL WARP ENDS	PICKS PER INCH (IN) FILLING	WEIGHT PER LINEAR YARD	LINEAR BREAKING STRENGTH (MINIMUM)
Regular or Streamer 1/	1-3/8 inch (35 mm)	420	80 (1 Thread Double Shot)	0.26 oz	80 lbs
Miniature 1/	11/16 inch (17.5 mm)	210	80 (1 Thread Double Shot)	0.13 oz	40 lbs
Streamer 2/	2-3/4 inch (70 mm)	660	70 (1 Thread Single Shot)	0.31 oz	90 lbs

1/ Filling: 50/2-3 ply; 1 100/3 ply; 50/6 ply or 150/2 denier
Warp: 40/2 ply denier

2/ Filling: 50/2 ply denier
Warp: 50/2 ply denier

3.4.2.1 Physical requirements exceptions. The following ribbons are exceptions to 3.4. Physical requirements shall be as specified on the applicable specification sheet.

MIL-DTL-11589/80 - Ribbon, Legion of Merit
MIL-DTL-11589/83 - Ribbon, Medal of Honor
MIL-DTL-11589/86 - Ribbon, Medal for Merit
MIL-DTL-11589/119 - Ribbon, Philippine Defense
MIL-DTL-11589/125 - Ribbon, Presidential Unit Citation (Navy)
MIL-DTL-11589/140 - Ribbon, Superior Cadet Award ROTC (Junior Division)
MIL-DTL-11589/141 - Ribbon, Superior Cadet Award ROTC (Senior Division)
MIL-DTL-11589/143 - Ribbon, Superior Cadet Award ROTC (Military School Division)
MIL-DTL-11589/148 - Ribbon, World War I Victory

3.4.3 Color pattern. The color shall be as specified on the applicable specification sheet.

3.5 Finish. The ribbon shall have a plain finish or moire finish as specified on the applicable specification sheet.

Source: https://assist.dla.mil -- Downloaded: 2026-10-17T18:22Z
Check the source to verify that this is the current version before use.

3.6 Workmanship. The finish ribbon shall conform to the quality and grade of product established by this specification.

4. VERIFICATION

4.1 Classification of inspections. The inspection requirements specified herein are classified as follows:

a. First article inspection (see 4.3).

b. Conformance inspection (see 4.4).

4.2 Inspection conditions. Unless otherwise specified, all inspection shall be performed in accordance with the test conditions specified in 4.4 and 4.5.

4.3 First article inspection. Inspection and testing of the first article (see 3.2) shall be made of a completely finished item for all provisions of this specification applicable to the end product examination and tests.

4.4 Conformance inspection. Inspection shall be in accordance with the provisions set forth herein, except where otherwise indicated (see 6.2).

4.4.1 Conformance inspection sampling.

4.4.1.1 Conformance inspection of components. In addition to the verification provisions of the subsidiary specifications and drawings, inspection shall be performed on components and materials listed in Table II for the conformance inspection of characteristics shown therein.

TABLE II. Conformance Inspection of Components.

CHARACTERISTICS	REQUIREMENT PARAGRAPH	TEST METHOD	RESULTS REPORTED AS
Fiber identification	3.3.1	1/	Pass or Fail
Brightness	3.3.1	1/	Pass or Fail
Number of Filaments	3.3.1	Count	Nearest Whole Number
Color	3.3.2	1/	Pass or Fail
COLORFASTNESS:			
Crocking	3.3.2.1	1/	Pass or Fail
Wet-dry Cleaning	3.3.2.1	1/	Pass or Fail
Water	3.3.2.1	1/	Pass or Fail
Light	3.3.2.1	1/	Pass or Fail
Ply	3.4.2	1/	Pass or Fail
Denier	3.4.2	1/	Nearest Whole Number

NOTE: The sample unit shall be one tube, cone, spool, etc. The lot size shall be expressed in units of one pound.

1/ Certification of compliance will be acceptable for these requirements.

4.4.1.1.1 Certification of compliance. Materials listed below may be accepted on the basis of the contractor's certificate of compliance for requirements specified in applicable paragraphs of this specification.

Source: https://assist.dla.mil -- Downloaded: 2026-10-17T18:22Z
Check the source to verify that this is the current version before use.

COMPONENTS	REQUIREMENT PARAGRAPH
Rayon yarn	3.3.1

4.4.2 Inspection of the end item. Defects found during the inspection shall be classified in accordance with the list shown in 4.4.2.1 and 4.4.2.2.

4.4.2.1 Yard-by-yard inspection. The required yardage of each roll shall be inspected and visual defects classified as listed in Table III. A continuous defect shall be counted as one defect for each warpwise yard or fraction thereof in which it occurs. The sample unit shall be one linear yard. The number of rolls from which the sample is to be selected shall be in accordance with Table IV. An approximately equal number of yards shall be examined in each roll.

4.4.2.1.1 Examination for defects in finish, design, material, construction, workmanship, and marking.

TABLE III. Classification of Visual Defects.

DEFECTS	CLASSIFICATION	
	MAJOR	MINOR
Hole, cut or tear	X	-
Smash	X	-
Broken or missing yarn:		
-Two or more contiguous, regardless of length	X	-
-Single, 2 inches or more missing	X	-
-Single, less than 2 inches missing	-	X
Floats or skips:		
-Multiple more than 1/2 inch in combined warp and fill directions, or single more than 2 inches in length	X	-
-Multiple, 1/2 inch or less in combined warp and filling directions, or single less than 2 inches in length	-	X
Knot - oversized	-	X
Heavy filling bar or heavy place, clearly visible 1/	-	X
Kinks - multiple, clearly visible 1/	-	X
Open place or crack (opening at widest point with three or more yarn diameters or sequence of smaller openings that may result in a weak spot	X	-
Spot, stain or streak:		
- Clearly visible 1/2 inch or more in combined warp and fill directions 1/	X	-
- Clearly visible less than 1/2 inch in combined warp and fill directions 1/	-	X
Crease or wrinkle embedded	X	-
Filling yarn showing between ground and binder	-	X
Overall width less than specified	X	-
Overall width more than 1/16 inch wider than specified	-	X
Taeguk not correct design	X	-

1/ Clearly visible at normal inspection distance (approximately 16-22 inches).

4.4.2.2 Overall inspection. Each defect listed shall be counted not more than once in each roll examined. The sample unit shall be one roll. The sample selected for this inspection shall be as specified in Table IV.

Source: https://assist.dla.mil -- Downloaded: 2026-10-17T18:22Z
Check the source to verify that this is the current version before use.

Overall uncleanness.
Finish other than specified.
Uneven weaving throughout piece.
Selvage curled, folded, rolled, slack or loopy, torn continuously or intermittently over more than one half the roll.

TABLE IV. Acceptable Number of Defects.

SIZE IN YARDS	SAMPLE SIZE IN ROLLS	MAX. # OF DEFECTS APPLICABLE IN SAMPLE
Up to 1,300 1/	3	0
1,301 to 3,200	5	0
3,201 to 8,000	7	0
8,001 to 22,000	10	0
22,001 to 110,000	15	1
110,001 and up	25	1

4.4.3 End item testing. The methods of testing specified herein and as listed in Tables II and V shall be followed. The physical and chemical values specified in Section 3 apply to the average of the determinations made on a sample unit for test purposes as specified in the applicable conformance inspection method. The sample unit shall be 3 continuous yards of finished ribbon. The sample size for each characteristic shall be as follows and the lot shall be unacceptable if one or more units fail to meet any requirement specified:

Lot Size (Yards)	Sample Sizes
800 or less	2
801 to 22,000	3
22,001 and over	5

TABLE V. Testing of End Item.

CHARACTERISTIC	REQUIREMENT PARAGRAPH	TEST METHOD	# DETERMINED PER SAMPLE/UNIT	RESULTS REPORTED AS
Construction:		Visual		
Warp	3.4.2	1/		
Fill	3.4.2	1/		
Denier	3.4.2	4.5.1	6 2/	Pass or Fail 3/
Weight	3.4.2, 3.4.2.1	1/	1	Nearest 0.01 oz
Tensile Strength	3.4.2, 3.4.2.1	1/	1	Nearest pound 4/
Weave	3.4.1	Visual	1	Pass of Fail
Color Arrangement	Spec Sheet	Visual	1	Pass of Fail
Width of Individual Stripe	Spec Sheet	Visual	1	Pass of Fail

1/ Certification of compliance will be acceptable for these requirements.
2/ Average of six tests.
3/ Considered as passing if within plus or minus 8 denier.
4/ Except that the breaking strength of the ribbon shall be determined by testing the full width of ribbon including selvage.

4.5 Test.

4.5.1 Test for denier in end item. The denier for both the warp and filling yarn shall be determined from a finished piece of ribbon at least three (3) yards in length. A filling sample shall be obtained by pulling yarn from the ribbon, taking care not to stretch or distort the filling sample. A warp yarn sample shall be obtained by cutting the ribbon in the warp direction

Source: https://assist.dla.mil -- Downloaded: 2026-10-17T18:22Z
Check the source to verify that this is the current version before use.

and pulling out a warp end. Each warp end color shall be checked for denier. A sample length of ninety (90) centimeters shall be weighed on a yarn balance machine, such as the Universal Yarn Balance manufactured by the Alfred Suter Company, or equivalent, for both the warp and filling. Care should be taken not to stretch the samples in the measurement, but to apply enough tension to straighten the yarn and remove all kinks. The denier shall be determined by averaging the results of the six yarn samples.

5. PACKAGING

5.1 Packaging. For acquisition purposes, the packaging requirements shall be as specified in the contract or order (see 6.2). When actual packaging of materiel is to be performed by DOD personnel, these personnel need to contact the responsible packaging activity to ascertain requisite packaging requirements. Packaging requirements are maintained by the Inventory Control Point's packaging activity within the Military Department or Defense Agency, or within the Military Department's System Command. Packaging data retrieval is available from the managing Military Department's or Defense Agency's automated packaging files, CD-ROM products, or by contacting the responsible packaging.

6. NOTES

(This section contains information of a general or explanatory nature that may be helpful, but is not mandatory.)

6.1 Intended use. Ribbon covered by this specification is intended to be used as components in the fabrication of decorations, service and campaign medals, service ribbons and streamers required by the Department of Defense military services and various Federal agencies.

6.2 Acquisition requirements. Acquisition documents must specify the following:

a. Title, number and date of the specification.

b. Issue of DoDISS to be cited in the solicitation and/or the specific issue of individual documents referenced (see 2.1 and 2.2).

c. The title, number and date of the applicable specification sheet (see 1.2 and 2.1) with width of ribbon.

d. When a first article is not required (see 3.2).

e. Packaging to be used (see 5.1).

6.3 Subject term (key word) listing.

Decoration
Service Ribbon
Service Medal
Campaign Medal
Streamers

6.4 Changes from previous issue. Marginal notations are not used in this revision to identify changes with respect to the previous issue due to the extensiveness of the changes.

Source: https://assist.dla.mil -- Downloaded: 2026-10-17T18:22Z
Check the source to verify that this is the current version before use.

Custodians:
Army - IH
Air Force - 45
Navy - NU
Coast Guard - CG

Review activities:
Air Force - 32, 82, 99
Navy - MC
DLA - CT
DNA -DS
DISA - DC
NSA - NS
DIA - DI

Civil Agency Coordinating Activities:
COM
DOJ
DOJ - BOP
DOT
DOT - ACO
DOT - CGCT
EPA
NASA - NA

Preparing activity:
Army - IH

(Project No. 8455-0813)

Source: https://assist.dla.mil -- Downloaded: 2026-10-17T18:22Z
Check the source to verify that this is the current version before use.

STANDARDIZATION DOCUMENT IMPROVEMENT PROPOSAL

INSTRUCTIONS

1. The preparing activity must complete blocks 1, 2, 3, and 8. In block 1, both the document number and revision letter should be given.
2. The submitter of this form must complete blocks 4, 5, 6, and 7.
3. The preparing activity must provide a reply within 30 days from receipt of the form.

NOTE: This form may not be used to request copies of documents, nor to request waivers, or clarification of requirements on current contracts. Comments submitted on this form do not constitute or imply authorization to waive any portion of the referenced document(s) or to amend contractual requirements.

I RECOMMEND A CHANGE:	1. DOCUMENT NUMBER MIL-DTL-11589F	2. DOCUMENT DATE (YYMMDD) 951215

3. DOCUMENT TITLE
RIBBON, AWARDS, GENERAL SPECIFICATION FOR

4. NATURE OF CHANGE (Identify paragraph number and include proposed rewrite, if possible. Attach extra sheets as needed.)

5. REASON FOR RECOMMENDATION

6. SUBMITTER

a. NAME (Last, First, Middle Initial)	b. ORGANIZATION	
c. ADDRESS (Include Zip Code)	d. TELEPHONE (Include Area Code) (1) Commercial (2) AUTOVON (If applicable)	7. DATE SUBMITTED (YYMMDD)

8. PREPARING ACTIVITY

a. NAME The Institute of Heraldry, U.S. Army	b. TELEPHONE (Include Area Code) (1) Commercial (703) 806-4990 (2) AUTOVON DSN 656-4990
c. ADDRESS (Include Zip Code) Technical & Production Division 9325 Gunston Road, Room S112 Fort Belvoir, VA 22060-5579	IF YOU DO NOT RECEIVE A REPLY WITHIN 45 DAYS, CONTACT: Defense Quality and Standardization Office 5203 Leesburg Pike, Suite 1403, Falls Church, VA 22041-3466 Telephone (703) 756-2340 AUTOVON 289-2340

DD Form 1426, OCT 89

Source: https://assist.dla.mil - Downloaded: 2026-01-17 18:22
Check the source to verify that this is the current version before use.